

Independent for Life

The 4-Week Starter Plan

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The promise (read this first)

The 7-day guide proved you can get measurably steadier in a week. This plan is what comes after: **four weeks, three 30-minute sessions a week, one progressive system** — and at the end of it, you'll move better in daily life than you do today. Getting out of chairs, climbing stairs, carrying groceries, catching your balance — the same everyday things, done with more strength and more confidence.

This is not a harder version of the guide. It's the next level: longer sessions, new movements, real progression from week to week, and a test at the end that shows you — in your own numbers — how far you've come.

Who this is for: adults 50+ who finished the 7-day guide (or equivalent) and want a real training plan. Beginners and returners welcome. If a movement feels too easy, the progression is right there. If it feels too hard, so is the regression. You will never be stuck.

What you need: - A sturdy chair with no wheels (your training partner for all four weeks) - A clear wall and a kitchen counter (for push-up progressions and balance support) - Two water bottles to start; a pair of light dumbbells (3–5 lb) by Week 3 - A bottom stair with a handrail (standard ~7-inch rise) - Clear floor space and supportive, closed-toe shoes

How this connects to the guide: everything from the 7 days carries over — the one-cue-per-rep rule, the chair-always-there rule, the two baseline tests (you'll do them again in Week 1 and Week 4). Nothing here re-teaches what the guide taught. We build on it.

Safety — non-negotiable (read before Session 1)

1. **Check with your doctor first** if you have a heart condition, uncontrolled blood pressure, dizziness or fainting, joint replacements, osteoporosis, or anything that makes you unsure. The doctor checklist from the guide applies to this plan too — same movements, longer sessions.
2. **Pain is a stop sign, not a suggestion.** Muscle effort and mild fatigue are fine. Sharp pain, joint pain, chest pain, or dizziness means stop immediately, sit down, and don't push through it.
3. **The chair is always there.** Every standing exercise in this plan has a chair-supported version. There is no prize for doing a movement unsupported before you're ready.
4. **Breathe.** Exhale on the effort (standing up, pushing, pulling), inhale on the easy part. Never hold your breath and strain — especially if you have high blood pressure.
5. **Spine stays neutral under load.** We never bend or twist the spine with weight in this program. Your back stays long and still; your hips and legs do the moving.
6. **Clear your space.** Move rugs, cords, and clutter out of your training area before every session.
7. **This plan is exercise instruction, not medical advice.** It doesn't diagnose or treat anything. If something hurts or feels wrong, ask your doctor or a qualified trainer — don't guess with your body.

How to use this plan

The schedule. Three sessions a week, on non-consecutive days if you can (Mon / Wed / Fri works; Tue / Thu / Sat works). Each week has the same three session types in the same order:

- **Session A — Lower body + balance** (legs, hips, steadiness)
- **Session B — Upper body + core** (push, pull, trunk)
- **Session C — Full body** (everything together, plus balance)

12 sessions total. If life moves a session, just do it the next day — don't double up to "catch up."

How a session runs (30 minutes). Every session follows the same clock: - **Warm-up — 5 min** (same routine every time; printed in full in Session 1, compact form after) - **Main block — ~20 min** (the circuit for that session) - **Cool-down — 5 min** (same routine every time)

How to progress. Each movement has three versions: **regression** (easier), **standard**, and **progression** (harder). Start every movement at standard unless the guide taught you otherwise. Take the progression when you can finish all prescribed reps with good form and feel like you could do 2–3 more clean reps. Drop to the regression any time form breaks down — that's smart training, not failure.

How loading works. Water bottles are the starting weight, not the forever weight. The same exercise gets harder simply by holding more weight: water bottles → light dumbbells (3–5 lb) → heavier dumbbells. That's the beauty of weights — any exercise can challenge any level, because the load is adjustable. If you already own dumbbells, skip the bottles and start there. The rule never changes: if form breaks, the weight is too heavy.

The four weeks. - Week 1 — Learn the moves. 2 rounds per session. The goal isn't exhaustion; it's owning every movement and its one key cue. Write down your baseline

test numbers on Day 1. - **Week 2 — Add a round.** 3 rounds per session, same movements, same reps. This is where work capacity builds. Expect honest muscle tiredness the next day — that's the plan working. - **Week 3 — Slow it down, load it up.** Back to 2 rounds, but every rep runs on a slow tempo (3 seconds down, 1 second pause, 3 seconds up) and light dumbbells join the upper-body and carry movements. Fewer rounds, harder reps. - **Week 4 — Test week.** 2 rounds at normal tempo. Session 12 ends with the retest: the same two baseline tests from Week 1. Compare the numbers. That's your proof.

What "done" looks like each week. - End of Week 1: you can do every movement with its key cue from memory. - End of Week 2: you finished all 3 rounds of every session. - End of Week 3: the slow tempo humbled you (good), and the light weights felt manageable, not scary. - End of Week 4: your retest numbers beat Week 1. Whatever the gap is — that's four weeks of real change.

The Starter Guarantee

Do all 12 sessions, then retest on Day 28. If your numbers didn't improve, email us — you get your \$37 back. No forms, no interrogation. The program works when you work it; if it didn't work for you, you shouldn't pay for it.

Your baseline test (Session 1, before the warm-up — 5 minutes)

Same two tests as the guide, so the numbers are comparable. Write them in the tracker on the last page.

1. **Single-leg stand:** near a wall, lift one foot a few inches, time how long before you need to grab. Fingertips on the wall are fine — note whether you touched. Both legs.
2. **Sit-to-stand:** arms crossed over your chest, sturdy chair. How many full stand-ups in 30 seconds?

My numbers — Week 1: - Right leg: _ **seconds (touched wall? Y / N)** - Left leg: **seconds (touched wall? Y / N)** - Sit-to-stand: __ reps

The movement library

Every movement below appears in the sessions by name. Learn the **standard** version first. The **key cue** is the one thing to think about during the rep. **Common mistake** is what to watch for. **Regression** is your fallback; **progression** is your next step. **Skip if** tells you when to choose a different movement entirely.

Lower body

1. Chair squat Stand in front of your chair, feet hip-width apart, chair close behind your calves. Sit back and down until your buttocks lightly touch the chair — don't plop — then stand. *Key cue:* sit back like you're finding the chair behind you, knees tracking over toes. *Common mistake:* knees caving inward or the chest collapsing. Think "chest proud, knees out." *Regression:* hold the chair back or a counter for support; sit to a higher surface (firm cushion on the chair). *Progression:* sit-to-stand with arms crossed (no hands); then hold a water bottle or dumbbell at your chest (goblet). Goblet is the default loaded version — it teaches an upright torso. If holding weight at your chest bothers your shoulders or wrists, hold it at your sides (suitcase) instead. Whatever the load, the rule never changes: if form breaks, the weight is too heavy. *Skip if:* deep knee bending is painful — shorten the range and stay pain-free.

2. Glute bridge Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat and hip-width. Press through your heels and lift your hips until knees–hips–shoulders form a straight line. Lower slowly. *Key cue:* squeeze your glutes at the top like you're holding a coin. *Common mistake:* overarching the lower back at the top. Hips up, ribs down — a straight line, not a backbend. *Regression:* smaller range — lift halfway. *Progression:* pause 3 seconds at the top; then march — at the top, lift one knee a few inches, alternate. *Skip if:* getting down to and up from the floor is difficult — substitute standing hip extensions holding the chair (stand tall, press one leg straight back a few inches, squeeze the glute).

3. Step-up Face the bottom stair (standard ~7-inch rise), one hand on the rail. Step up with one foot, bring the other up, step back down with control. All reps on one leg, then switch. *Key cue:* push through the heel of the working leg — don't push off the back foot. *Common mistake:* pushing off the trailing foot, which unloads the working leg. The working leg does the work; the trail leg is just along for the ride. *Regression:* use a lower platform (a sturdy thick book or low step) with both hands on support. *Progression:* slow the step-down to 3 seconds; then a slightly higher step (still with the rail). *Skip if:* you've had a knee or hip replacement in the last 12 months — get your surgeon or physical therapist's clearance for step-ups specifically before adding them.

4. Standing hip abduction Stand sideways to your chair, inside hand on the chair back. Keeping the working leg straight and toes pointing forward (not out), lift the leg 6–8 inches to the side. Lower slowly. *Key cue:* stand tall — don't lean away from the lifting leg. *Common mistake:* leaning the torso away to "help" the leg up. Smaller lift with a tall torso beats a big lift with a lean. *Regression:* smaller lift (3–4 inches). *Progression:* hover your hand just above the chair instead of gripping it. *Skip if:* lateral hip pain (outer hip) is sharp — shorten the range or substitute seated marching.

5. Calf raise Stand behind your chair, both hands on the back. Rise onto the balls of your feet, pause, lower all the way down. *Key cue:* full range — all the way up, all the way down. No bouncing. *Common mistake:* bouncing off the bottom. Pause at the bottom every rep. *Regression:* one hand on the chair; smaller range. *Progression:* pause 2 seconds at the top; then single-leg calf raise with both hands on the chair for support.

Upper body

6. Wall push-up → countertop push-up *Wall:* hands on the wall at shoulder height, arms' length away. Bend elbows, bring chest toward the wall, press back. *Countertop:* same movement, hands on the kitchen counter, body in a straight line from head to heels. *Key cue:* body is one straight line — no sagging hips; elbows at 45°, not flared. *Common mistake:* sagging hips or flared elbows. Squeeze the glutes and belly to keep the line. *Regression:* wall version, feet closer to the wall (more upright = easier).

Progression: wall → countertop (lower incline = harder); then feet farther back, slower tempo, more reps. Countertop is the ceiling for this plan — we build strength here with tempo and volume, not by going to the floor. That's a deliberate safety choice for shoulders and wrists, not a limitation. *Skip if:* shoulder pain when pushing — stay very upright, shorten the range, and stay pain-free.

7. Water-bottle row Stand facing your chair, one hand on the seat, opposite foot slightly back, back flat like a tabletop. Hold a water bottle in the free hand, pull it to your ribcage, squeeze, lower slowly. *Key cue:* squeeze the shoulder blade — imagine pinching a pencil between your shoulder blades at the top. *Common mistake:* rounding the lower back or shrugging the shoulder to the ear. Back flat, shoulder away from the ear. *Regression:* lighter bottle or no weight; smaller range of motion. *Progression:* heavier bottle or dumbbell; pause 2 seconds at the top. *Skip if:* bending forward bothers your back — do it seated: sit tall, lean slightly forward, same pull and squeeze.

8. Overhead press *Seated (Weeks 1–2):* sit tall in your chair, bottles at shoulder height. Press overhead without arching your lower back; lower slowly. *Standing (Weeks 3–4):* same movement standing, chair in front for balance if needed. *Key cue:* ribs down — don't arch the lower back to get the weight up. *Common mistake:* leaning back to "help" the weight up. If you have to lean, the weight is too heavy. *Regression:* stay seated; lighter bottles; press to forehead height only. *Progression:* standing; then heavier dumbbells; slower lowering. *Skip if:* reaching overhead bothers your shoulders — stay with the seated version at a pain-free height, or substitute the chest press alternative below. **Shoulder flag:** if overhead reaching is painful, skip overhead pressing entirely and do a standing chest press instead (press the bottles forward from chest height, same ribs-down cue). Shoulders that complain about overhead work are telling the truth — listen.

Core

9. Dead bug Lie on your back, arms reaching toward the ceiling, knees bent with feet flat on the floor. Press your lower back into the floor. Slide one heel out along the floor,

bring it back, alternate — back stays glued down the whole time. *Key cue:* lower back pressed into the floor for the entire set. If it lifts, shorten the slide. *Common mistake:* letting the back arch as the leg extends. Smaller slide with a flat back beats a big slide with an arched back — every time. *Regression:* march in place lying down (tiny heel slides, 2–3 inches). *Progression:* slide the heel farther; then full dead bug — feet off the floor, extend opposite arm and leg (only if the back stays glued down). *Skip if:* getting down to and up from the floor is difficult — substitute the standing march, focusing on tall posture and a braced belly (imagine bracing for a gentle poke to the stomach).

10. Standing march Stand behind your chair, hands resting on the back. Lift one knee toward hip height, lower with control, alternate. Stand tall throughout. *Key cue:* lift the knee and stand tall — no leaning back. *Common mistake:* leaning back as the knee rises, which dumps the work into the lower back. Tall torso, braced belly. *Regression:* lower knee lift (a few inches); grip the chair firmly. *Progression:* hover hands above the chair; then hold light bottles at your sides.

Balance

11. Weight shift Stand with feet hip-width, chair in front. Shift all your weight slowly onto one foot — feel it move fully into that foot — then shift to the other. Slow and deliberate. *Key cue:* feel the weight arrive fully in each foot before shifting back. *Common mistake:* rushing. Two minutes slow beats thirty seconds fast. *Regression:* hands on the chair; shift only partway. *Progression:* feet closer together (narrow stance); hover hands.

12. Heel-to-toe stand → heel-to-toe walk *Stand:* place one foot directly in front of the other, heel to toe, near a wall. Hold. *Walk:* take slow heel-to-toe steps along the wall, eyes forward. *Key cue:* eyes forward, not down — your balance follows your gaze. *Common mistake:* looking at the feet. Pick a spot ahead at eye level. *Regression:* fingertips on the wall; heel-to-instep instead of heel-to-toe (wider = easier); shorter holds. *Progression:* stand → walk; longer distances along the wall.

13. Single-leg stand Near a wall, lift one foot a few inches. Time it or count breaths. Fingertips on the wall are fine. *Key cue:* pick one spot on the wall and stare at it. *Common mistake:* holding the breath. Keep breathing — tension without breath-holding. *Regression:* toe of the lifted foot lightly touching the floor ("kickstand"). *Progression:* hover your hand just off the wall; longer holds. (We keep eyes open — always.)

Carry (introduced Week 3)

14. Farmer's carry Hold a water bottle or light dumbbell in each hand at your sides. Stand tall — shoulders back, ribs down — and walk slowly across the room and back. Keep a chair or counter within reach along your path. *Key cue:* tall posture the whole walk — don't let the weights pull your shoulders forward. *Common mistake:* shrugging the shoulders up to the ears or leaning forward. Shoulders back and down, gaze forward. *Regression:* lighter bottles or no weight at all — the "posture walk" (Weeks 1–2 use this: walk tall with empty hands, same cues). Shorter distance. *Progression:* heavier dumbbells; longer distance. *Skip if:* grip is the limiting factor — that's normal and it improves; shorten the distance rather than skipping. If walking itself is unsteady, stay with the posture walk near the counter until balance is solid.

The 12 sessions

Every session runs the same clock: **warm-up 5 min** → **main block ~20 min** → **cool-down 5 min**. The warm-up and cool-down never change — they're printed in full in Session 1 and repeated in compact form after that. Rest as needed; the clock is a guide, not a boss. Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Standard warm-up (5 min): march in place 60s (chair nearby, easy pace) → arm circles 30s forward + 30s back → hip circles 30s each direction → ankle rolls 30s per foot → gentle torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Standard cool-down (5 min): standing quad stretch holding chair 30s/leg → calf stretch against wall 30s/leg → chest opener (fingers interlaced behind back, lift gently) 30s → standing hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + slow deep breathing 60s.

WEEK 1 — Learn the moves (2 rounds per session)

Goal: own every movement and its key cue. Move slowly. Nothing should feel rushed.

Session 1 — A: Lower body + balance

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Baseline test first (5 min, before the warm-up): single-leg stand each leg + 30-second sit-to-stand. Record your numbers.

Warm-up (5 min): March in place for 60 seconds at an easy pace, chair nearby. Arm circles: 30 seconds forward, 30 seconds back. Hip circles: 30 seconds each direction. Ankle rolls: 30 seconds per foot. Gentle torso twists: 30 seconds. Shoulder rolls: 30 seconds.

Main block — 2 rounds: 1. Chair squat × 10 — *sit back, knees over toes* 2. Glute bridge × 10 — *squeeze the coin at the top* (or standing hip extension if floor work is hard) 3. Step-up × 8 per leg (hand on rail) — *push through the heel* 4. Standing hip abduction × 10 per leg — *stand tall, don't lean* 5. Calf raise × 12 — *full range, up and down* 6. Single-leg stand — 20 seconds per leg — *stare at one spot*

Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): Standing quad stretch holding the chair, 30 seconds per leg. Calf stretch against the wall, 30 seconds per leg. Chest opener — fingers interlaced behind

your back, lift gently — 30 seconds. Standing hamstring stretch, 30 seconds per leg. Neck rolls and slow deep breathing, 60 seconds.

Session 2 — B: Upper body + core

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds: 1. Wall push-up × 10 — *straight line, elbows at 45°* 2. Water-bottle row × 10 per arm — *pinch the pencil* 3. Overhead press, seated × 10 — *ribs down* (see the shoulder flag in the library — pain-free range only) 4. Dead bug (heels slide) × 8 per side — *back glued to floor* (or standing march if floor work is hard) 5. Standing march × 10 per leg — *tall, knee up* 6. Heel-to-toe stand — 20 seconds per leg — *eyes forward*

Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 3 — C: Full body

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds: 1. Chair squat × 10 2. Wall push-up × 8 3. Water-bottle row × 8 per arm 4. Glute bridge × 10 5. Standing march — 30 seconds 6. Heel-to-toe stand — 20 seconds per leg

Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

End of Week 1 check: can you do every movement with its key cue from memory? If yes, Week 1 is done — regardless of how it felt.

WEEK 2 — Add a round (3 rounds per session)

Same movements, same reps. The only change: 3 rounds. This is where work capacity builds — expect honest muscle tiredness the next day. That's the plan working.

Session 4 — A: Lower body + balance

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 3 rounds: chair squat × 10 → glute bridge × 10 → step-up × 8/leg → hip abduction × 10/leg → calf raise × 12 → single-leg stand 20s/leg. Rest 60–90s between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 5 — B: Upper body + core

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 3 rounds: wall push-up ×10 → row ×10/arm → overhead press seated ×10 → dead bug ×8/side → standing march ×10/leg → heel-to-toe stand 20s/leg. Rest 60–90s between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 6 — C: Full body

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 3 rounds: chair squat ×10 → wall push-up ×8 → row ×8/arm → glute bridge ×10 → standing march 30s → heel-to-toe stand 20s/leg. Rest 60–90s between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

End of Week 2 check: did you finish all 3 rounds of every session? If yes, your work capacity just leveled up.

A note before Week 3

You've just done the hardest volume week of this plan — and you finished it. That tells you something: your body adapts fast when the programming is right.

Week 3 introduces slow tempo and light weights. After that, there's one more level: **Independent for Life: The 6-Week Strength Foundations for Adults 50+** — the coached program this plan feeds into. Eighteen sessions, concierge text coaching, weekly form-video review, and a guarantee measured in three abilities: 5 unassisted chair stands, the 20-lb carry, the 30-second single-leg stand.

The next cohort starts **[DATE]** — 20 seats, enrollment closes **[DATE]**. If you already know you want the full program, you don't have to wait until Week 4 to claim a seat. (Your \$37 for this plan credits toward it.)

If you're not ready, that's fine — finish Weeks 3–4 strong. The invitation stands at the end too.

WEEK 3 — Slow it down, load it up (2 rounds, slow tempo + light weights)

*Back to 2 rounds — but every rep runs on a **3-1-3 tempo** (3 seconds down, 1 second pause, 3 seconds up), and light dumbbells (3–5 lb) join the upper-body work. Fewer rounds, harder reps. If a movement's form breaks at the slow tempo, drop to its regression — tempo exposes weak form, which is the point.*

*New this week: the **farmer's carry** in Session C (water bottles or light dumbbells, short walks, support nearby). Push-ups move to the **countertop** incline; overhead press goes **standing** (stay seated if overhead reaching bothers your shoulders — see the shoulder flag).*

Session 7 — A: Lower body + balance

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds, 3-1-3 tempo: 1. Chair squat × 8 (slow) 2. Glute bridge × 8 (slow — 3s up counts too) 3. Step-up × 6 per leg (3 seconds down) 4. Standing hip abduction × 8 per leg (slow) 5. Calf raise × 10 (3s up, 3s down) 6. Single-leg stand — 25 seconds per leg (hover hand if ready)

Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 8 — B: Upper body + core

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds, 3-1-3 tempo: 1. Countertop push-up × 8 (slow) 2. Dumbbell row × 8 per arm (slow — squeeze at the top) 3. Overhead press, standing × 8 with dumbbells (slow; *ribs down*; seated is fine — see shoulder flag) 4. Dead bug × 6 per side (slow slides; *back glued down*) 5. Standing march × 8 per leg (slow, tall) 6. Heel-to-toe walk — slow steps along the wall, 30 seconds

Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 9 — C: Full body

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby ☐ walking path clear. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds, 3-1-3 tempo: 1. Chair squat × 8 (slow) 2. Countertop push-up × 8 (slow) 3. Dumbbell row × 8 per arm (slow) 4. Glute bridge × 8 (slow) 5.

Farmer's carry — dumbbells or full water bottles at your sides, walk slowly across the room and back (~30 seconds). Tall posture. Support within reach. (Not steady enough yet? Do the posture walk — same tall walk, empty hands.) 6. Heel-to-toe walk — 30 seconds along the wall

Rest 60–90 seconds between rounds.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

End of Week 3 check: did the slow tempo humble you? Good — that means the muscles worked harder with zero extra risk. The weights should feel manageable, not scary.

WEEK 4 — Test week (2 rounds, normal tempo)

Consolidation week. Normal tempo again — you'll be surprised how strong the slow week made you. Move well, then prove it: Session 12 ends with the retest.

Session 10 — A: Lower body + balance

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds: chair squat ×10 → glute bridge ×10 → step-up ×8/leg → hip abduction ×10/leg → calf raise ×12 → single-leg stand 25s/leg. Rest 60–90s between rounds. Take any progressions you've earned.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 11 — B: Upper body + core

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds: countertop push-up ×10 → dumbbell row ×10/arm → overhead press (standing or seated — your call, see shoulder flag) ×10 → dead bug ×8/side → standing march ×10/leg → heel-to-toe walk 30s. Rest 60–90s between rounds. Take any progressions you've earned.

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Session 12 — C: Full body + RETEST

Before you start: ☐ floor clear ☐ chair sturdy, no wheels ☐ water nearby ☐ walking path clear. Stop for sharp pain, dizziness, or chest pain.

Warm-up (5 min): march 60s → arm circles 30s fwd/30s back → hip circles 30s each way → ankle rolls 30s/foot → torso twists 30s → shoulder rolls 30s.

Main block — 2 rounds: chair squat ×10 → countertop push-up ×8 → dumbbell row ×8/arm → glute bridge ×10 → farmer's carry ~30s → heel-to-toe walk 30s. Rest 60–90s between rounds.

Retest (5 min — this is the moment): rest 2–3 minutes, then repeat the two baseline tests exactly as in Session 1. Same wall, same chair, same effort. - Single-leg stand: right _ **seconds (touched? Y/N)**, left **seconds (touched? Y/N)** - **Sit-to-stand:** __ reps in 30 seconds

Write them in the tracker. Compare with Week 1. *That's four weeks of real change, in your own numbers.*

Cool-down (5 min): quad stretch 30s/leg → calf stretch 30s/leg → chest opener 30s → hamstring stretch 30s/leg → neck rolls + breathing 60s.

Your tracker (one page — print it, stick it on the fridge)

Sessions completed — check the box, note anything worth remembering (a progression you earned, a movement that needs work).

Week	Session	Type	Done	Notes
1	1	A — Lower + balance (+ baseline test)	☐	
1	2	B — Upper + core	☐	

Week	Session	Type	Done	Notes
1	3	C — Full body	☐	
2	4	A — Lower + balance	☐	
2	5	B — Upper + core	☐	
2	6	C — Full body	☐	
3	7	A — Lower + balance (tempo)	☐	
3	8	B — Upper + core (tempo + load)	☐	
3	9	C — Full body (tempo + carry)	☐	
4	10	A — Lower + balance	☐	
4	11	B — Upper + core	☐	
4	12	C — Full body + RETEST	☐	

Balance self-checks

Test	Week 1	Week 4	Change
Single-leg stand, right (sec / touched?)	/	/	
Single-leg stand, left (sec / touched?)	/	/	
Sit-to-stand, 30 sec (reps)			

What comes next

You've spent four weeks building the foundation: movement quality, work capacity, slow-tempo strength, and your first loaded carry. Here's the honest picture of where that foundation can go.

Independent for Life: The 6-Week Strength Foundations for Adults 50+ is the program this plan was designed to feed into — 18 sessions, three a week, same 30-minute format you already know. What it adds on top of what you've just done:

- **Progressive loaded strength.** The light dumbbells from Week 3 become the starting point, not the ceiling. Structured loading for legs, hips, back, and shoulders — the kind of weight-bearing work that supports bone health and makes daily life (stairs, groceries, grandkids) genuinely easier.
- **Loaded carries as a core skill.** You tasted the farmer's carry in Weeks 3–4. The 6-week program builds it into a full progression — heavier, longer, varied — because carrying strength is independence strength. The goal: carry 20 lbs across the room with confidence.
- **The chair-stand goal.** We train the exact skill of standing from a chair without using your hands — progressively, safely — until it's yours.
- **The 30-second balance goal.** Single-leg balance trained as a skill, week after week, until 30 seconds unassisted is comfortable.
- **Form checks.** Every movement, checked. You'll know you're doing it right instead of wondering.

This starter plan is "start here." The 6-week program is "keep going, with weight and with coaching." Nothing in the starter plan is repeated there — it picks up where Session 12 left off.

If you're not ready for six weeks, that's fine — repeat Weeks 3–4 of this plan as maintenance. The worst thing you can do now is stop. The second worst is to rush. You know which pace is yours.

The next cohort starts [DATE] — 20 seats, enrollment closes [DATE]. If you know you want in, claim your seat now rather than waiting for the rush at the deadline.

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Questions about a movement, a pain, or whether you're ready for the next step? Ask — that's what a trainer is for.